

Still life

Although still life has never been seen as the most important genre, it has often been the most realistically portrayed. The term derives from the Dutch *still-leven* ('inanimate objects'). Some ancient Greek and Roman frescoes and mosaics included *trompe l'oeil* ('fool the eye') depictions of plants and food. Early Christian and Byzantine art occasionally featured stylized and symbolic still life elements, and by the 15th century still life arrangements were included in some paintings to show the artist's skill.

Dutch Golden Age artists such as Steenwyck painted detailed, lifelike still lifes, which were bought by middle-class citizens. In Spain, artists such as Cotán and Velázquez painted *bodegóns*, or still lifes incorporated into domestic scenes. In France, still life became noticed through Chardin's work in the 18th century, and a century later, Cézanne used them to investigate structure. In the 20th century, artists such as Giorgio Morandi explored still life using various materials and methods, while Cubists and Pop artists particularly embraced the genre.



Cézanne, *Still Life with a Curtain*, c.1898